

Securing Your Family Computer

A Practical Windows 11 Safety Guide

You do not need to be a tech expert. Just a plan — and one step at a time.

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Version: May 2026

GUIDE NOTICE

This is an educational guide for home Windows 11 computers, not a guarantee of security or professional legal, financial, or technical advice. Windows, Microsoft Family Safety, browser settings, DNS services, password managers, and security tools change over time, so treat this as a living guide and verify current vendor menus before making changes. Use these steps at your own risk, back up important files before making major changes, and consult a trusted professional when a setting could affect work, school, accessibility, or critical household needs.

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SECURITY LAYERS

Use this model to explain the guide to your family. Each layer helps cover the gaps left by the layer below.

Family Awareness — Conversations, safe reporting, and scam recognition
Account Security — Unique passwords, MFA, recovery codes, and standard users
Device Protection — Updates, Microsoft Defender, ransomware controls, and backups
Network Filtering — Ad blocking, DNS filtering, SafeSearch, and parental controls

Figure 1. Security works best in layers.

INTRODUCTION: WHY YOUR FAMILY COMPUTER NEEDS THIS

A new laptop or desktop is usually configured for convenience first. That makes sense: most people want to get online, install their apps, and start using the computer quickly. The problem is that convenience-focused defaults are not always the safest choices for a family computer.

This guide walks you through a safer setup. It focuses on practical controls that reduce the risk from scams, malware, ransomware, inappropriate content, weak passwords, and accidental mistakes. Nothing here makes a computer impossible to attack, but these steps make your home computer much harder to abuse.

The goal is not fear. The goal is confidence. You should understand what each setting does, why it matters, and how to undo it if a legitimate app or family need requires a change.

Who This Guide Is For

This guide is written for parents, grandparents, caregivers, and anyone responsible for a shared home computer. It assumes you are using Windows 11. Many of the same ideas apply to macOS, Chromebooks, phones, and tablets, but the exact menus will differ.

How to Use This Guide

- Read the guide once to understand the overall plan.
- Complete one or two steps per sitting instead of rushing through everything at once.
- Use the checklist at the end of each step before moving on.
- Involve older children where appropriate. The technical settings matter, but family conversations matter just as much.

The 5-Phase Plan

- Phase 1: Initial Setup and Account Hygiene — safer accounts and fewer unnecessary permissions.
- Phase 2: Digital Identity Protection — stronger passwords, MFA, and account recovery planning.
- Phase 3: Built-In Defense and Anti-Malware — Windows security features are enabled and checked.
- Phase 4: Network and Browser Guardrails — the browser and DNS layer block more risky content.
- Phase 5: The Living Security Routine — the family has a realistic monthly routine and clear safety rules.

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INITIAL SETUP AND ACCOUNT HYGIENE

Laying the foundation before anything else

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STEP 1: Connect Safely and Install Updates First

Before you install apps, sign into accounts, or let children use the computer, connect it to a trusted network and install all available updates. Updates close known security holes, fix stability problems, and update built-in protections.

Connect to a Safe Network

- Use your private home Wi-Fi or a trusted wired connection.
- Avoid setting up a new or reset computer on public Wi-Fi at coffee shops, hotels, airports, schools, or libraries.
- Keep the computer plugged in during the first update cycle.

Why this matters: A new computer may have been sitting in a box for months. During that time, Microsoft, browser vendors, and hardware vendors may have released important security fixes.

Run Windows Update

1. Click Start and type Windows Update.
2. Open Windows Update.
3. Click Check for updates.
4. Install everything offered under Important or Recommended updates.
5. Restart when prompted.
6. Return to Windows Update and check again until Windows reports the device is up to date.

Turn On Updates for Other Microsoft Products

7. In Windows Update, open Advanced options.
8. Turn on Receive updates for other Microsoft products.
9. Leave automatic updates enabled.

Important: Use Windows Update and your computer manufacturer's support app or website for drivers. Avoid random "driver updater" tools found in ads or pop-ups.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Computer is connected to a trusted home network.
- ☐ Windows Update has been run until no important updates remain.
- ☐ Updates for other Microsoft products are enabled.
- ☐ The computer has restarted successfully after updates.

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STEP 2: Create a Separate Administrator Account

Most home computers are used every day from an administrator account. That is convenient, but it gives everyday activity too much power. If malware runs while you are logged into an administrator account, it may be able to install itself, change system settings, or disable protections more easily.

A safer setup uses one administrator account for system changes and separate standard accounts for daily use. Think of the administrator account like the master key to your house: useful, but not something you carry around for every errand.

Create the Administrator Account

10. Open Settings > Accounts > Other users. Some Windows builds may show this area as Family & other users.
11. Select Add account.
12. If creating a local account, choose I don't have this person's sign-in information, then Add a user without a Microsoft account.
13. Use a plain name such as HomeAdmin, LocalAdmin, or FamilyAdmin.
14. Create a long, unique password. Store it on paper with important household documents, not in a text file on the computer.
15. After the account is created, change the account type to Administrator.
16. Sign into the new administrator account once to confirm it works before changing any other accounts.

Change Daily Accounts to Standard User

17. Return to Settings > Accounts > Other users.
18. Select the daily account used for browsing, email, schoolwork, games, and streaming.
19. Change its account type to Standard User.
20. Sign out and sign back in.

Important: Do not remove administrator rights from every account. Confirm the separate administrator account works first. Windows requires at least one administrator account for software installation, device changes, and troubleshooting.

What to expect: When a standard user tries to install software or change protected settings, Windows will prompt for the administrator password. That prompt is a security feature, not a problem.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ A separate administrator account exists.
- ☐ The administrator password is long, unique, and stored safely offline.
- ☐ Daily parent and child accounts are standard users.
- ☐ The administrator account has been tested.

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STEP 3: Create Individual Accounts for Every Family Member

Shared accounts create confusion and risk. Each person should have their own Windows account. Separate accounts keep files, browser history, saved passwords, app permissions, and parental controls isolated from one another.

Parent Accounts

- Each parent or adult should have a separate standard user account.
- Use the administrator account only when Windows asks for elevated permission or when you intentionally need to make system changes.

Children's Accounts

- Children should have child accounts connected to Microsoft Family Safety if you plan to use Microsoft's built-in parental controls.
- Use the child's real age or appropriate birth year so age-based controls work correctly.
- Avoid letting children use a parent's account. If a child accidentally downloads something unsafe or changes a setting, the problem is harder to contain from a shared account.

Create a Child Account

21. Open Settings > Accounts > Family.
22. Choose Add someone or Add a family member.
23. Create or sign in with the child's Microsoft account.
24. Confirm the child appears in your Microsoft family group.
25. Leave the child account as a standard user.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Each regular user has a separate account.

- ☐ Children are not using a parent account.
- ☐ Children's accounts are standard users.
- ☐ Child accounts are connected to the family group if Microsoft Family Safety will be used.

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STEP 4: Reduce Unnecessary Data Sharing

Windows includes privacy settings for advertising, diagnostics, location, camera, microphone, speech, and app permissions. Some data sharing is useful. Some is unnecessary for a family computer. The point is to choose intentionally instead of accepting every default.

Open Privacy Settings

26. Open Settings > Privacy & security.
27. Work through the categories listed below.

Recommended Privacy Changes

- General: Turn off personalized ads using the advertising ID.
- General: Turn off suggested content in Settings if you do not want promotional recommendations.
- Speech: Turn off online speech recognition if your family does not use dictation or voice features.
- Diagnostics & feedback: Keep required diagnostic data on, but turn off optional diagnostic data if you do not want extra usage information sent to Microsoft.
- Tailored experiences: Turn this off if you do not want Microsoft using diagnostic data for personalized tips or ads.
- Activity history: Turn off storage of activity history if you do not use timeline-style features.
- Location: Turn location services off unless maps, weather, device-finding, or other trusted apps need it.
- Camera and microphone: Review app access and turn off access for apps you do not recognize or trust.
- App permissions: Review contacts, calendar, notifications, documents, pictures, and video permissions.

Note: If something stops working after a privacy change, return to the same page and re-enable the setting for the specific app that needs it.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Advertising ID and suggested content have been reviewed.

- ☐ Optional diagnostic and tailored experience settings have been reviewed.
- ☐ Location access has been limited to apps that genuinely need it.
- ☐ Camera and microphone permissions have been reviewed.

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FORTIFYING YOUR DIGITAL IDENTITY

Protecting the accounts that protect everything else

5**STEP 5: Set Up a Password Manager**

Password reuse is one of the most common ways families lose accounts. When one website is breached, attackers try the same email and password combination on banks, email accounts, shopping sites, school portals, and social media. This attack method is called credential stuffing. A password manager stores strong, unique passwords for each account so your family does not have to memorize them. You remember one strong master password, and the manager handles the rest.

Recommended Password Managers

- Bitwarden: Strong free individual plan, open-source, and a solid choice for most families.
- 1Password: Polished family experience with strong sharing features.
- Dashlane: User-friendly option with strong security features.

For a single adult, a free password manager may be sufficient. For household sharing, emergency access, and organized family vaults, a paid family plan is worth considering.

Getting Started with Bitwarden

28. Go to bitwarden.com and create an account.
29. Choose a long master password or passphrase. A phrase of several unrelated words is easier to remember and harder to guess than a short, complex password.
30. Write the master password on paper and store it with important household documents.
31. Install the Bitwarden browser extension for the browser you use most.
32. Start saving passwords as you log into websites.
33. Replace reused or weak passwords on your most important accounts first: email, banking, Microsoft, Google, Apple, school, and shopping accounts.

Browser Password Saving

After your password manager is working, turn off browser password saving so passwords do not become scattered across multiple locations. One dedicated vault is easier to secure, audit, back up, and manage as a family.

Passkeys

When important websites offer passkeys, consider using them. Passkeys reduce phishing risk because they are tied to the real website and your device. Keep the password manager in use as well, because not every site supports passkeys and you will still need a place for recovery codes, notes, and older passwords.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ A password manager account has been created.
- ☐ The master password is long and stored safely offline.
- ☐ The browser extension is installed.
- ☐ Critical accounts are being updated with unique passwords.
- ☐ Browser password saving is disabled once the dedicated password manager is working.

6**STEP 6: Turn On Multi-Factor Authentication**

A password is one factor. Multi-factor authentication — often called MFA or 2FA — requires something in addition to the password. That second factor may be an authenticator app, a push approval, a passkey, or a physical security key.

MFA is one of the highest-value security improvements you can make. If a password is stolen in a breach or phishing attack, MFA can prevent the attacker from signing in.

Best MFA Options

- Best: Passkeys or physical security keys, especially for email and financial accounts.
- Very good: Authenticator apps such as Microsoft Authenticator, Google Authenticator, or the built-in TOTP features in 1Password or Bitwarden.
- Better than nothing: SMS text message codes. Use SMS only when better options are not available.

Set Up MFA on Google

34. Go to myaccount.google.com/security.
35. Open 2-Step Verification.
36. Choose an authenticator app, passkey, or security key when available.
37. Save backup codes and store them offline.

Set Up MFA on Microsoft

38. Go to account.microsoft.com/security.
39. Open Advanced security options.
40. Turn on two-step verification or add sign-in methods such as Microsoft Authenticator, a passkey, or a security key.
41. Save recovery codes and store them offline.

Important: Do not rely on one phone as the only way into every account. Phones can be lost, broken, stolen, or replaced. Backup codes and recovery options matter.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ MFA is enabled on email accounts.
- ☐ MFA is enabled on Microsoft and Google accounts.
- ☐ MFA is enabled on banking, shopping, school, and social media accounts where available.
- ☐ Backup codes are printed or written down and stored safely offline.

7**STEP 7: Set Up Account Recovery Before You Need It**

Losing access to an email, Microsoft, Google, Apple, or banking account can become a serious household problem. Recovery settings should be reviewed while everything is working normally, not during an emergency.

Google Account Recovery

- Go to myaccount.google.com/security.
- Review your recovery email address and recovery phone number.
- Review signed-in devices and remove old or unrecognized devices.
- Review recent security activity.

Microsoft Account Recovery

- Go to account.microsoft.com/security.
- Review sign-in methods and recovery options.
- Remove old devices and outdated recovery details.
- Confirm recovery phone numbers and email addresses are current.

Family Emergency Planning

Every household should have a private digital emergency plan. This does not mean every child needs access to every password. It means a spouse, trusted adult, or estate plan can recover critical accounts if something happens.

- Store the password manager master password with important documents or estate paperwork.
- Store MFA backup codes with those documents.
- Document which email address is used for recovery on critical accounts.
- Review this plan once a year.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Recovery email and phone number are current for Google.
- ☐ Recovery email and phone number are current for Microsoft.

- ☐ Old devices have been removed from major accounts.
- ☐ A private family emergency recovery plan exists.

8**STEP 8: Clean Up Cloud Privacy and Connected Apps**

Cloud accounts collect and connect a great deal of information: searches, location history, YouTube history, app permissions, sign-in history, and third-party app access. This step is about reviewing those choices and removing access you no longer need.

Google Privacy Review

42. Go to myaccount.google.com/data-and-privacy.
43. Review Web & App Activity. Pause it or enable auto-delete if you do not want long-term history stored.
44. Review Location History. Pause it if your family does not use Google Maps Timeline.
45. Review YouTube History. Pause or enable auto-delete if you do not want long-term viewing history stored.
46. Open Third-party apps & services and remove apps you no longer use or recognize.

Microsoft Privacy Review

47. Go to account.microsoft.com/privacy.
48. Review browsing, search, location, and activity history.
49. Clear stored history you do not need.
50. Review apps and services connected to your Microsoft account and remove any you no longer use.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Google activity settings have been reviewed.
- ☐ Google third-party app access has been cleaned up.
- ☐ Microsoft privacy dashboard has been reviewed.
- ☐ Old or unrecognized connected apps have been removed.

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BUILT-IN DEFENSE AND ANTI-MALWARE

Using the protection already built into Windows

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STEP 9: Check Microsoft Defender and Windows Security

Windows 11 includes Microsoft Defender Antivirus and the Windows Security app. For most families, Microsoft Defender is a capable built-in antivirus solution. The important part is making sure it is enabled, updated, and not disabled by another product or by malware.

Open Windows Security

51. Click Start and type Windows Security.
52. Open the Windows Security app.
53. Review the dashboard. Green checkmarks indicate good status. Yellow or red warnings require attention.
54. Open Virus & threat protection.
55. Open Manage settings under Virus & threat protection settings.

Settings to Review

- Real-time protection should be on.
- Cloud-delivered protection should be on.
- Automatic sample submission is recommended for stronger threat detection, but families may review the privacy trade-off before enabling it.
- Tamper protection should be on so malicious software cannot easily disable Defender settings.

Run an Initial Full Scan

56. In Virus & threat protection, choose Scan options.
57. Select Full scan.
58. Click Scan now.
59. Allow the scan to finish before heavy use.

If Defender finds something: Choose Quarantine when you are unsure. Quarantine isolates the file without immediately trusting it. Do not choose Allow unless you are certain the file is safe.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Windows Security dashboard has been reviewed.

- ☐ Real-time protection is on.
- ☐ Cloud-delivered protection is on.
- ☐ Tamper protection is on.
- ☐ A full scan has been completed.

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STEP 10: Enable Ransomware Protection Carefully

Ransomware encrypts files and demands payment to unlock them. Windows includes Controlled Folder Access, a ransomware protection feature that limits which apps can modify protected folders. It is useful, but it can also block legitimate apps until you add them to the allowed list.

Turn On Controlled Folder Access

60. Open Windows Security.
61. Go to Virus & threat protection.
62. Open Manage ransomware protection.
63. Turn on Controlled folder access.
64. Open Protected folders and confirm that Documents, Pictures, Desktop, Music, and Videos are listed.
65. Add any custom family folders where important files are stored.

Allow Trusted Apps When Needed

Photo editors, scanners, backup tools, or older programs may be blocked when they try to save files in protected folders. If that happens, do not turn off the entire feature right away. Instead, add the trusted app through Allow an app through Controlled folder access.

Important: Ransomware protection is not a substitute for backups. Controlled Folder Access can help, but backups are your recovery plan if prevention fails.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Controlled Folder Access is turned on.
- ☐ Important folders are listed as protected.
- ☐ The family understands that legitimate apps may need to be added to the allowed list.
- ☐ Backups are still treated as required protection.

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STEP 11: Set Up Real Backups

Backups protect against hardware failure, theft, accidental deletion, fire, and ransomware. A family computer should not depend on only one copy of photos, documents, schoolwork, or tax records.

The 3-2-1 rule: Keep three copies of important data, on two different types of storage media, with one copy stored off-site.

Layer 1: OneDrive Folder Backup

OneDrive can back up and sync the Desktop, Documents, and Pictures folders. This is particularly useful for families using Microsoft 365. A Microsoft 365 Family subscription includes 1 TB of cloud storage per person. Free Microsoft accounts include significantly less storage.

66. Click the OneDrive cloud icon in the taskbar.
67. Sign in with the correct Microsoft account.
68. Open OneDrive settings.
69. Open Sync and backup.
70. Choose Manage backup.
71. Turn on backup for Desktop, Documents, and Pictures.

Important: OneDrive is also a sync tool. If a file is deleted or changed, that change will sync. OneDrive has version recovery features, but it should not be your only backup layer.

Layer 2: External Drive Backup with File History

72. Buy an external drive large enough for your family files. For most households, 1 TB or 2 TB is a practical starting point.
73. Plug in the external drive.
74. Open Control Panel.
75. Go to System and Security > File History.
76. Choose the external drive and turn File History on.
77. Run the first backup.
78. After the backup completes, safely eject and disconnect the drive if you are not actively backing up.

Why this matters: An external drive that remains permanently connected may be reachable by ransomware. A backup drive stored offline is significantly safer.

Layer 3: Optional Second Off-Site Backup

For irreplaceable photos, legal documents, or business files, consider a second off-site copy. This could be a cloud backup service, a second external drive stored at a trusted family member's home, or a secure backup product that maintains version history.

Test Your Backups

A backup is only trustworthy if you can restore from it. Once a year, restore a harmless test file from OneDrive and from the external drive, then confirm the file opens correctly.

✓ **STEP CHECKLIST**

- ☐ OneDrive folder backup has been reviewed or enabled.
- ☐ External drive backup is configured with File History.
- ☐ The external drive is disconnected after backups when practical.
- ☐ At least one restore test is scheduled annually.

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NETWORK AND BROWSER GUARDRAILS

Blocking more trouble before it reaches the screen

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STEP 12: Install a Trustworthy Ad and Tracker Blocker

Ads are not only annoying — malicious ads, often called malvertising, can appear on legitimate websites and direct users toward scams, fake downloads, phishing pages, or exploit attempts. A reputable blocker reduces both clutter and risk.

Recommended Browser Extensions

- Microsoft Edge: uBlock Origin from the Microsoft Edge Add-ons store.
- Mozilla Firefox: uBlock Origin from the Firefox Add-ons site.
- Google Chrome: uBlock Origin Lite, because Chrome's newer extension rules may limit or remove support for the full uBlock Origin extension.

Important: Some extensions call themselves ad blockers but allow paid advertising, collect unnecessary data, or imitate trusted tools. Install only from the official browser extension store and verify the exact name and developer.

Install on Each Browser Profile

Extensions are often installed per browser profile. If each family member has a separate profile, install the blocker in each profile that is used for regular browsing.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ A reputable content blocker is installed in the main adult browser profile.
- ☐ Children's browser profiles have the appropriate blocker installed.
- ☐ Suspicious or duplicate ad-blocking extensions have been removed.

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STEP 13: Set Up DNS-Level Filtering

DNS is the internet's address lookup system. When you type a website name, DNS finds where that site is hosted. A family-safe DNS service can block known malware, phishing sites, adult content, and other risky categories before the browser even connects.

Option A: Cloudflare Family DNS

Cloudflare provides free family DNS options. For malware and adult-content blocking, use the following addresses:

- IPv4 preferred DNS: 1.1.1.3
- IPv4 alternate DNS: 1.0.0.3
- IPv6 preferred DNS: 2606:4700:4700::1113
- IPv6 alternate DNS: 2606:4700:4700::1003

For malware-only blocking without adult-content filtering, Cloudflare uses 1.1.1.2 and 1.0.0.2.

Option B: NextDNS

NextDNS offers more customization. It can block malware, phishing, trackers, adult content, gambling, newly registered domains, and other categories depending on your configuration. It is a strong choice when you want more control and reporting than a simple public DNS address provides.

Set DNS on One Windows Computer

79. Open Settings > Network & internet.
80. Choose Wi-Fi or Ethernet depending on your connection.
81. Open hardware properties or DNS server assignment.
82. Change DNS from Automatic to Manual.
83. Enter the DNS addresses for your chosen provider.
84. Save and test normal browsing.

Set DNS on the Router for Whole-Home Coverage

Changing DNS on one computer protects that computer. Changing DNS on the router protects most devices on your home network. Router menus vary, but the setting is usually found under Internet, WAN, DHCP, LAN, or Advanced network settings.

Important: DNS filtering is helpful but not perfect. VPNs, mobile data, browser built-in secure-DNS settings, and technically savvy users can bypass it. Use it as one layer, not the only layer.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ A family-safe DNS provider has been chosen.
- ☐ DNS is configured on the computer or router.
- ☐ IPv6 DNS has been configured if the home internet uses IPv6.
- ☐ The family understands DNS filtering is one layer, not a guarantee.

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STEP 14: Configure Browser Profiles and Safe Search

Browser profiles separate bookmarks, history, extensions, saved settings, and sign-in sessions. For children, profiles also make it easier to apply age-appropriate rules.

Use Microsoft Edge for Family Safety Web Filtering

Microsoft Family Safety web and search filtering works through Microsoft Edge. If you rely on Microsoft Family Safety for children's web filtering, require children to use Edge and block other browsers from their child accounts.

Set Up Edge Profiles

85. Open Microsoft Edge.
86. Click the profile icon in the top-right corner.
87. Choose Add profile.
88. Create a profile for each family member.
89. Sign each child profile into the child's Microsoft account if using Family Safety.

Safe Search Settings

- For Microsoft Family Safety, turn on Filter inappropriate websites and searches for the child account. This works with Edge and Bing filtering.
- For Google accounts, use Google SafeSearch. For children with Google Family Link, manage SafeSearch from the Family Link app or Google family settings.
- For DuckDuckGo, set Safe Search to Strict in the search settings.

Note: Safe Search reduces explicit search results. It does not replace parental controls, DNS filtering, or conversations with your child.

Child-Safe Start Page

Set children's browser profiles to open a trusted start page such as a school portal, homework site, or another parent-approved page.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Each family member has a separate browser profile.
- ☐ Children use Edge if Microsoft Family Safety web filtering is required.
- ☐ Other browsers are blocked for child accounts if needed.
- ☐ Safe Search is enabled for major search engines used by the family.

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STEP 15: Set Up Microsoft Family Safety

Microsoft Family Safety can manage screen time, app and game limits, content filtering, activity reporting, and family group settings. It is particularly useful for Windows families when children use Microsoft accounts.

Get Started

90. Go to family.microsoft.com or open the Microsoft Family Safety app.
91. Sign in with the parent's Microsoft account.
92. Confirm each child account appears in the family group.
93. Open the child's profile and review Windows, Edge, apps, games, and screen time settings.

Recommended Settings

- Screen time: Set daily limits or bedtime hours for school nights.
- Apps and games: Set age limits and block apps that are not age-appropriate.
- Web and search: Turn on Filter inappropriate websites and searches for Edge.
- Browser control: Block other browsers if you need Microsoft Family Safety filtering to be enforceable.
- Activity reporting: Turn on reports and review them as conversation starters, not as secret surveillance.

Balance controls with trust: Parental controls work best when children know they exist and understand why. Tell children that mistakes can be reported without panic or punishment. A child who hides a mistake can turn a small problem into a much larger one.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Children are in the Microsoft family group.
- ☐ Screen time rules are configured.
- ☐ App and game age limits are configured.
- ☐ Edge web filtering is enabled if desired.
- ☐ Other browsers are blocked if filtering must be enforceable.
- ☐ The family has discussed why the controls exist.

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THE LIVING SECURITY ROUTINE

Keeping your family protected month after month

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STEP 16: Follow a Monthly Maintenance Routine

Security is not a one-time setup. Software changes, new scams emerge, children grow older, and family needs evolve. The goal is a simple routine you can actually maintain.

Monthly Tasks

- Check Windows Update and install any pending updates.
- Check browser updates. In Edge, go to Settings > About Microsoft Edge. In Chrome, go to Settings > About Google Chrome. In Firefox, go to Help > About Firefox.
- Review Windows Security for warnings.
- Confirm backups are running.
- Review recent Family Safety activity and discuss anything concerning.

Quarterly Tasks

- Run a full Microsoft Defender scan.
- Check the password manager for reused, weak, or breached passwords if your plan includes breach monitoring.
- Review camera, microphone, location, and app permissions.
- Check the router manufacturer's app or website for firmware updates.

Annual Tasks

- Restore one test file from OneDrive and one test file from the external backup to confirm they work.
- Review user accounts on the computer and remove any accounts no longer needed.
- Review recovery email addresses, phone numbers, and MFA backup codes.
- Review third-party app access for Google, Microsoft, Apple, and other major accounts.
- Review passwords. Change passwords that are weak, reused, exposed in a known breach, or suspected to be compromised. Do not change strong, unique passwords simply because the calendar year changed.

Make it teachable: Walk a teenager through the monthly routine. Checking updates, backups, and account security is practical digital literacy that will serve them for life.

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ A monthly calendar reminder has been created.
- ☐ Quarterly scan and password review are scheduled.
- ☐ Annual backup restore test is scheduled.
- ☐ The family knows who is responsible for maintenance.

17**STEP 17: Create a Family Cyber Agreement**

Technical settings help, but people remain the most important security layer. A family agreement turns safety into a shared commitment instead of a secret list of rules.

Threats Every Family Member Should Understand**Phishing**

Phishing is a fake email, text message, website, or phone call designed to trick someone into sharing information, clicking a link, downloading a file, or sending money. Common signs include:

- Urgent messages: "Your account will be closed today."
- Mismatched sender addresses: a message claims to be from a trusted company but comes from a strange domain.
- Unexpected attachments: invoices, receipts, forms, or documents you did not request.
- Fake links: the button text looks normal, but the actual destination is a different site.

Scams and Scareware

Teach everyone to pause when something feels too good, too scary, or too urgent. Fake virus warnings, fake prize messages, gift card requests, romance scams, and refund scams all depend on emotional pressure to make people act without thinking.

Download Safety

- Download apps only from official stores or the software company's official website.
- Do not download "free" versions of paid software from unfamiliar websites.
- If a website claims the computer has a virus and instructs you to download a cleaner, close the page immediately.
- Ask an adult before installing games, mods, cheats, browser extensions, or unknown tools.

Online Safety for Children

- Never share a home address, school name, phone number, passwords, or private photos with someone you only know online.
- Be cautious with in-game "friends" offering free items, currency, skins, or cheats in exchange for account access.
- Tell a parent if anyone asks you to keep a conversation secret.

- Tell a parent if anything online feels uncomfortable, threatening, embarrassing, or confusing.

Important: Most important child rule: A trustworthy person does not ask a child to keep secrets from their family. If someone online asks for secrecy, that is a red flag.

Family Cyber Agreement

Print this section, discuss it together, and adjust it for your household.

FAMILY CYBER AGREEMENT

- We will not share passwords with anyone outside the family.
- We will ask before downloading new apps, games, browser extensions, or software.
- We will not click links in unexpected emails or messages until we have verified them.
- We will not share our home address, school, phone number, or private photos with people we only know online.
- We will tell a parent or trusted adult immediately if something online feels strange, upsetting, or unsafe.
- We agree that mistakes happen. Our family is a safe place to report problems quickly without hiding them.

Parent/Guardian: _____ **Date:** _____

Parent/Guardian: _____ **Date:** _____

Child/Family Member: _____ **Date:** _____

Child/Family Member: _____ **Date:** _____

✓ STEP CHECKLIST

- ☐ The family has discussed phishing and scams.
- ☐ Children know what information not to share online.
- ☐ Children know they can report mistakes without fear of punishment.
- ☐ The family agreement has been reviewed and signed.

CONCLUSION: A SAFER FAMILY COMPUTER

By completing these steps, your family computer now has multiple protective layers: safer user accounts, stronger passwords, multi-factor authentication, better recovery planning, Microsoft Defender protections, ransomware controls, backups, browser filtering, DNS filtering, parental controls, and family rules for safer online behavior.

This does not make the computer invincible. No home computer is invincible. But most attacks against families are opportunistic. Attackers look for easy targets: reused passwords, missing updates, unprotected accounts, unsafe downloads, and people who feel pressured into clicking quickly. This guide helps your family avoid being the easy target.

The most important next step is consistency. Keep the monthly maintenance routine, test backups once a year, and keep talking with your children about online safety. Digital safety is not one setting. It is a household habit.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

My name is Logan Goodwin, and I wrote this guide because I believe digital safety should be easier for everyday families to understand and put into practice. A lot of cybersecurity advice is written for businesses, IT departments, or people who already know the technical language. I wanted this guide to be different — practical, clear, and useful for a parent, grandparent, caregiver, or anyone trying to make a family computer safer.

My background is in information technology, systems administration, and cybersecurity. I have spent years working with computers, networks, troubleshooting, system setup, and security planning. My training includes industry standards and coursework connected to areas such as CompTIA Security+ and Project+, but I believe the most important skill is being able to take complicated technical ideas and turn them into steps people can actually use at home.

I live in New Hampshire with my wife, Christine. My goal with this guide is simple: to help individuals and families feel more confident, more informed, and more in control of their digital lives. Technology should not feel impossible to manage. With the right plan, the right habits, and a little patience, families can build safer digital spaces one step at a time.

Cybersecurity should not be something families fear. It should be something they can learn, practice, and use to protect the people they care about.

— Logan Goodwin

APPENDIX A: QUICK REFERENCE CARD

Important Places to Check

- Windows Update: Settings > Windows Update
- Windows Security: Search Windows Security from the Start menu
- Microsoft Family Safety: family.microsoft.com
- Google Account Security: myaccount.google.com/security
- Google Account Privacy: myaccount.google.com/data-and-privacy
- Microsoft Account Security: account.microsoft.com/security
- Microsoft Privacy Dashboard: account.microsoft.com/privacy
- OneDrive Backup: OneDrive icon > Settings > Sync and backup > Manage backup
- File History: Control Panel > System and Security > File History

Monthly Maintenance Checklist

- ☐ Run Windows Update.
- ☐ Check browser updates.
- ☐ Review Windows Security for warnings.
- ☐ Confirm backups are running.
- ☐ Review parental-control activity reports.
- ☐ Talk with children about anything unusual.

The 5 Golden Rules for Every Family Member

- Use a different password for every account.
- Enable MFA on important accounts.
- Do not click unexpected links or attachments.
- Download software only from official sources.
- Report online mistakes or unsettling messages quickly.

Signs a Computer May Be Infected

- The computer suddenly becomes much slower than usual.
- The browser homepage or search engine changes by itself.
- Pop-up ads appear when no browser window is open.
- Windows Security or antivirus protection is disabled unexpectedly.
- Files have strange extensions or will not open.
- A ransom note appears on screen.

If You Suspect Ransomware

94. Disconnect from Wi-Fi or unplug the Ethernet cable immediately.

95. Disconnect external drives and network storage if attached.
96. Do not sign into more accounts from the infected computer.
97. If you cannot disconnect from the network, power the computer down to help stop the spread.
98. Use a clean device to research next steps or contact a trusted professional.
99. Restore from known-good backups rather than paying criminals whenever possible.

APPENDIX B: MASTER COMPLETION CHECKLIST

Use this checklist after finishing the guide. It is also useful to revisit during your monthly maintenance routine.

Setup and Accounts

- ☐ Windows Update has been run until the device is fully current.
- ☐ A separate administrator account exists and has been tested.
- ☐ Everyday adult and child accounts are standard users.
- ☐ Each family member has their own Windows account.
- ☐ Privacy, location, camera, microphone, and app permissions have been reviewed.

Identity and Recovery

- ☐ A password manager is in use for important accounts.
- ☐ Critical accounts use unique passwords or passkeys.
- ☐ MFA is enabled for email, Microsoft, Google, banking, school, shopping, and social accounts where available.
- ☐ Backup or recovery codes are stored offline.
- ☐ Recovery email addresses, phone numbers, and trusted devices are current.
- ☐ Old connected apps and unrecognized account access have been removed.

Device Protection and Backups

- ☐ Windows Security shows no unresolved warnings.
- ☐ Microsoft Defender real-time protection, cloud-delivered protection, and tamper protection are on.
- ☐ A full Defender scan has been completed.
- ☐ Controlled Folder Access has been reviewed and tested if enabled.
- ☐ OneDrive folder backup is enabled if it fits the family plan.
- ☐ An external or second-location backup exists for important files.
- ☐ A test restore has been scheduled or completed.

Browser, Network, and Family Controls

- ☐ A reputable ad or content blocker is installed where appropriate.
- ☐ Family-safe DNS is configured on the router or computer if desired.
- ☐ Each family member has a separate browser profile.
- ☐ Safe Search is enabled for search engines used by the family.
- ☐ Microsoft Family Safety or another parental-control plan is configured for children if needed.

- ☐ Children know which browsers and accounts they are expected to use.

Ongoing Routine and Family Agreement

- ☐ Monthly update, backup, and Windows Security review reminder is on the calendar.
- ☐ Quarterly full scan and password review are scheduled.
- ☐ Annual restore test and recovery-information review are scheduled.
- ☐ The family has discussed phishing, scams, downloads, online privacy, and safe reporting.
- ☐ The Family Cyber Agreement has been reviewed and signed.

APPENDIX C: SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

The following sources were used to align technical recommendations with vendor and government guidance. Links and product behavior were reviewed on May 25, 2026, but services and menus can change.

Microsoft Family Safety — Filter websites and searches: <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/family-safety/filter-websites-and-searches-using-microsoft-family-safety>

Microsoft Family Safety — Block or unblock apps: <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/family-safety/block-or-unblock-apps-with-microsoft-family-safety>

Microsoft — Virus and threat protection in Windows Security: <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/virus-and-threat-protection-in-the-windows-security-app-1362f4cd-d71a-b52a-0b66-c2820032b65e>

Microsoft Learn — Enable Controlled Folder Access: <https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/defender-endpoint/enable-controlled-folders>

Microsoft — Back up your folders with OneDrive: <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/office/back-up-your-folders-with-onedrive-d61a7930-a6fb-4b95-b28a-6552e77c3057>

Microsoft — Backup and restore with File History: <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/backup-and-restore-with-file-history-7bf065bf-f1ea-0a78-c1cf-7dcf51cc8bfc>

Cloudflare — 1.1.1.1 for Families setup: <https://developers.cloudflare.com/1.1.1.1/setup/>

Cloudflare — IP addresses for 1.1.1.1 for Families: <https://developers.cloudflare.com/1.1.1.1/ip-addresses/>

NIST SP 800-63B — Digital Identity Guidelines: Authentication: <https://pages.nist.gov/800-63-4/sp800-63b.html>

CISA — I've Been Hit By Ransomware!: <https://www.cisa.gov/stopransomware/ive-been-hit-ransomware>

Google — SafeSearch settings: <https://support.google.com/websearch/answer/510>

Bitwarden — Password Manager Plans: <https://bitwarden.com/help/password-manager-plans/>

Microsoft — Backup, restore, and recovery in Windows: <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/backup-restore-and-recovery-in-windows-e6d629c4-2568-4406-814f-209a2af06ef7>

This is a living educational guide. Verify current settings with the vendor before making changes.